18TH-CENTURY EUROPEAN ARMIES

Between 1700 and the French Revolution of 1789, the military commanders of the major European powers – France, Britain, Austria, Prussia, and Russia – aspired to an ideal of rational order. Regular armies were maintained by the state and supplied with standard equipment and uniforms. Infantry recruited from the lower classes were depersonalized by discipline and drill, so that in battle they would execute orders like automata. On campaign, armies were supplied from magazines (military storehouses) through an extensive supply train. This slowed their movements but reduced destructive foraging. Battles were fought on open ground, with artillery, cavalry, and infantry combining in aggressive manoeuvres that often resulted in heavy casualties.

PRUSSIAN INFANTRYMAN

The Prussian army was the most admired force in 18th-century warfare, renowned for its discipline and drill. Mostly peasant conscripts, the men who formed Prussia's infantry were not inspired by any devotion to state or nation. They were trained like animals, by the building up of conditioned reflexes through repeated punishment. Any clumsiness on the parade ground, where they spent many hours every day, would instantly merit a blow with a cane or the flat of a sword. More serious infringements resulted in flogging or even execution.

The product of this system was a man who could execute the 22 actions required to fire a flintlock musket in around 30 seconds. He could deploy rapidly from marching column into battle line and, when ordered, would advance unarmoured in tight formation across open ground in the face of musket and cannon fire. He was expected to have absolutely no individual will, carrying out every action on the command of an officer or NCO. This ideal of disciplined infantry was, needless to say, never achieved. On campaign, desertion was a constant problem, and on the battlefield, soldiers gripped by fear stopped loading their muskets properly, appearing to keep up with the volleys by firing primer powder only. Even so, Prussian infantry generally manoeuvred quickly on the battlefield, had effective firepower, and were daunting advancing with bayonets fixed.

> "IF MY SOLDIERS WERE TO BEGIN TO THINK, NOT ONE OF THEM WOULD REMAIN IN THE ARMY."
>
> **FREDERICK II OF PRUSSIA**, WHOSE VICTORIES WERE THE ENVY OF OTHER EUROPEAN RULERS



Battle of Hohenfriedberg, 1745
Frederick II's Grenadier Guards advance across the battlefield directly into the fire of the Austrians. These aggressive tactics contributed to a famous victory.